Dear Arlington Town Manager Jim Feeney and Superintendent Elizabeth Homan,

The MA Dept of Revenue maintains a list of all overrides and underrides for all MA municipalities over the past 38 years on its website:

https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=Votes.Prop2_5.OverrideUnderride

Sorting by the last column “amount” in descending order, note that the proposed $14.8M override is the largest in MA history. See attached pic.

databank@dor.state.ma.us

Select Municipalities: 304 selected | Select Fiscal Years: 38 selected | Select Departments: 10 selected | Select Win / Loss: WIN, LOSS | Select Override / Underride: Underride, Override | Submit | Export Table

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DOR Code	Municipality	Fiscal Year	Vote Date	Win / Loss	Yes Votes	No Votes	Vote Type	Department	Description	Amount ▾
284	Stoneham	2026	4/1/2025	LOSS	2,909	3,432	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	$14.6 Million To Fund Public Safety, Education, Public Works And General Government Expenses Beginning July 1, 2025	14,600,000
178	Melrose	2026	11/4/2025	WIN	6,018	5,052	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	13,500,000
284	Stoneham	2027	12/9/2025	LOSS	3,600	3,643	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding School And Town Expenses For Fy27	12,500,000
046	Brookline	2024	5/2/2023	WIN	7,516	4,799	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Question 2a Operating Override	11,983,367
207	Newton	2003	4/30/2002	WIN	14,251	13,542	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	General Government And School Expenditures	11,500,000
213	North Reading	2025	6/18/2024	LOSS	1,807	2,438	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	School And General Government Budgets	10,000,000
281	Springfield	1990	6/1/1989	LOSS	14,163	17,724	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Public Safety,Health,Schls	10,000,000
344	Winchester	2020	3/26/2019	WIN	2,849	1,901	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operating Budget And Building Stab Fund	10,000,000
271	Shrewsbury	2022	5/4/2021	WIN	4,344	2,781	Override	SCHOOL	Muni And School Operating Budget	9,500,000
284	Stoneham	2027	12/9/2025	WIN	4,001	3,274	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding School And Town Expenses For Fy27	9,300,000
207	Newton	2023	3/14/2023	LOSS	9,472	10,595	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Budget Override	9,175,000
189	Milton	2026	4/29/2025	WIN	5,564	3,227	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Purposes Of Funding Municipal Government Operational Override Of The Town And Schools ($8,800,000)	8,800,000
072	Dartmouth	2008	7/31/2007	LOSS	5,471	5,696	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Operating Budgets Of The Town And School	8,459,000
026	Belmont	2025	4/2/2024	WIN	5,151	4,060	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Supplement Cap Budget & Town, School Oper Budgets	8,400,000
207	Newton	2014	3/12/2013	WIN	9,653	8,203	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding Municipal And School Operating	8,400,000
042	Bridgewater	2026	6/21/2025	LOSS	2,583	3,300	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operational Override	8,008,272
040	Braintree	2025	6/26/2024	WIN	5,493	2,764	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Purposes Of Funding The Following Departmental Expenses: General Municipal Government ($2,500,000), School Department ($4,000,000 And To Fund An Override Stabilization Fund For Gener Municipal And School Department Operations (1,500,000) For The Fiscal Yea	8,000,000
131	Hingham	2024	4/24/2023	WIN	3,515	2,123	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	7,890,467
178	Melrose	2025	6/18/2024	LOSS	4,296	5,174	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding School,City, And Public Safety Personnel, Associated Benefits, And Services	7,700,000
046	Brookline	2016	5/5/2015	WIN	6,325	3,958	Override	SCHOOL	Fund Additional Enrollment In Brookline Public Schools And Expenditures In Municipal Departments	7,665,000
246	Reading	2017	10/18/2016	LOSS	2,795	4,097	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	General Operation	7,500,000
088	Easton	2026	6/10/2025	LOSS	2,253	3,760	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	7,300,000
020	Barnstable	2005	11/4/2003	LOSS	5,903	9,461	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Municipal And School Budget	7,200,000
100	Framingham	2003	6/11/2002	WIN	6,877	6,536	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding General Operating Expenses	7,173,239
010	Arlington	2025	11/7/2023	WIN	7,951	4,964	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Operating Override	7,000,000
198	Natick	2026	3/25/2025	WIN	4,659	3,040	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operational Override	7,000,000
199	Needham	2003	11/5/2002	LOSS	4,579	9,186	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding Infrastructure Maintenance Programs	6,970,000
101	Franklin	2025	6/11/2024	LOSS	5,542	5,778	Override	SCHOOL	Operating Bdgt	6,800,000
002	Acton	2025	4/30/2024	WIN	3,191	3,154	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Public Schools And Muni Government	6,600,000
046	Brookline	2019	5/8/2018	WIN	5,412	2,371	Override	SCHOOL	Funding The Cost Of Expenditures In The Public Schools	6,575,425
197	Nantucket	2024	5/23/2023	WIN	1,096	994	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Affordable Housing Override	6,500,000
211	North Attleborough	2019	4/3/2018	WIN	4,330	3,216	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding	6,500,000
336	Weymouth	2016	8/4/2015	LOSS	5,066	6,716	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Departmental Expenses	6,500,000
010	Arlington	2012	6/7/2011	WIN	7,226	6,366	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Operating Budgets Of Town And School	6,490,000
026	Belmont	2022	4/6/2021	LOSS	3,542	4,547	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Supplement Capital Budget And Town And Schools Operating Budgets	6,400,000

Now you know where Arlington's $14.8M override amount was determined; Arlington wants to be #1!

Filtering on just “wins”, the second picture shows the top 25 successful overrides in history. Arlington claims 4 of the top 25 spots for all time (38 years) largest overrides in MA history.

DOR Code	Municipality	Fiscal Year	Vote Date	Win / Loss	Yes Votes	No Votes	Vote Type	Department	Description	Amount ▾
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344	Winchester	2020	3/26/2019	WIN	2,849	1,901	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operating Budget And Building Stab Fund	10,000,000
271	Shrewsbury	2022	5/4/2021	WIN	4,344	2,781	Override	SCHOOL	Muni And School Operating Budget	9,500,000
284	Stoneham	2027	12/9/2025	WIN	4,001	3,274	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding School And Town Expenses For Fy27	9,300,000
189	Milton	2026	4/29/2025	WIN	5,564	3,227	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Purposes Of Funding Municipal Government Operational Override Of The Town And Schools ($8,800,000)	8,800,000
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207	Newton	2014	3/12/2013	WIN	9,653	8,203	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding Municipal And School Operating	8,400,000
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002	Acton	2025	4/30/2024	WIN	3,191	3,154	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Public Schools And Muni Government	6,600,000
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010	Arlington	2012	6/7/2011	WIN	7,226	6,366	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Operating Budgets Of Town And School	6,490,000
046	Brookline	2009	5/6/2008	WIN	5,236	4,305	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding School, Police, Fire, And Library Depts. Etc	6,200,000
010	Arlington	2006	6/11/2005	WIN	7,126	6,570	Override	SCHOOL	Fund Town And School Budgets	6,000,000
105	Georgetown	2026	5/12/2025	WIN	1,659	1,348	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	6,000,000
220	Norwood	2020	6/3/2019	WIN	5,629	1,821	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	For Municipal Government, School Department Operations And Establishing A Stabilization Fund For Both	5,950,000
010	Arlington	2020	6/11/2019	WIN	8,655	4,029	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Town And School Operating Budget	5,500,000
271	Shrewsbury	2015	6/3/2014	WIN	7,102	2,704	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Municipal And School Operating And Capital Expenses	5,500,000
244	Randolph	2009	4/1/2008	WIN	3,578	2,901	Override	SCHOOL	Operating Randolph Public Schools	5,480,738
178	Melrose	2020	4/2/2019	WIN	6,084	4,875	Override	SCHOOL	General Operation Of School	5,180,000
197	Nantucket	2022	6/15/2021	WIN	1,147	432	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Purpose Of Supporting The Operation Of Our Island Home	5,000,000
164	Lynnfield	2026	6/4/2025	WIN	1,897	1,042	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Fy26 Budget	4,650,000
348	Worcester	1992	6/1/1991	WIN	17,997	16,380	Override	SCHOOL	Funding School Department Positions	4,583,000
344	Winchester	2003	4/16/2002	WIN	4,465	3,390	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	General Operating Budget	4,550,000
026	Belmont	2016	4/7/2015	WIN	4,733	3,837	Override	SCHOOL	Supplementing The Capital Budget Of The Town And School Operating Budgets	4,500,000

The last image shows Arlington overrides only. Each of Arlington's last 4 overrides were in the top 10 overrides of all time in state history at the time of the vote.

DLS
DIVISION OF LOCAL SERVICES
MA DEPARTMENT OF REVENUE

Data Analytics and Resources Bureau

Proposition 2½ Override and Underride Votes
Data current as of 02/15/2026

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Select Municipalities: Arlington | Select Fiscal Years: 38 selected | Select Departments: 10 selected | Select Win / Loss: WIN, LOSS | Select Override / Underride: Underride, Override | Submit | Export Table

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010	Arlington	2020	6/11/2019	WIN	8,655	4,029	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Town And School Operating Budget	5,500,000
010	Arlington	2012	6/7/2011	WIN	7,226	6,366	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Operating Budgets Of Town And School	6,490,000
010	Arlington	2006	6/11/2005	WIN	7,126	6,570	Override	SCHOOL	Fund Town And School Budgets	6,000,000
010	Arlington	1991	6/1/1990	WIN	8,828	7,731	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	General Operating Budget	2,520,000
010	Arlington	1990	6/1/1989	LOSS	5,805	6,078	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Operating Expenses Of Town And Schools	2,269,528

Arlington has demonstrably poor financial management, more so than *every* other MA community. Override advocates use fear (cut teachers!, trash will pile up!) to raise property taxes that benefit fewer and fewer residents. For those paying attention, there is already plans for an override in 2030; many Arlington officials believe we need overrides every 3 years, each larger than all other overrides in state history in perpetuity.

Only Brookline comes close to Arlington's funding operating budgets through frequent overrides. Note, Brookline has a budget almost twice as large as Arlington's budget ($450M vs $250M). Why do cities rarely have overrides (sans Newton)? How does Arlington (and a handful of other towns) have a structural deficit that most other towns, many with larger budgets and populations, do not?

YMMV - your money might vanish

Stephen Harrington

bcc more people